

Book II - The Spiral and the Block

Part 2 - The Mythology of Media

Chapter 16 - The Hobbit and the Shire

The Hobbit and the Shire: On Staying Rooted in the Journey to Destroy the Ring

Why a Hobbit

Gandalf did not choose a warrior. He did not choose a king, a wizard, an elf lord, or a captain of men. He chose a hobbit — a small, barefoot creature from a place no one of importance had ever heard of, who had never left home and had no desire to.

Everyone questioned it. The dwarves questioned it. Elrond's council questioned it. Even Frodo questioned it. The ring had to be carried into the heart of the most dangerous place in the world and dropped into fire — and the one chosen for this task had never held a sword, never led an army, never stood in a hall of power.

That was the point.

The ring corrupts in proportion to power. The greater your strength, your ambition, your proximity to dominion, the faster it takes you. Gandalf knew this. It is why he refused to carry it himself. It is why Galadriel refused it — *"In place of a Dark Lord, you would have a queen, beautiful and terrible as the dawn."* She saw what she would become. The ring would not make her evil. It would make her *effective* — and her effectiveness, unchecked by limitation, would become indistinguishable from the thing she sought to destroy.

The hobbit can carry the ring because the hobbit does not want dominion. The hobbit wants a garden. A meal. A pipe on the front porch. A home. The ring whispers *power* and the hobbit thinks *what would I do with power?* The ring offers the world and the hobbit says *I already have a world — it is small and green and it has everything I need.*

The ring cannot corrupt what does not reach for it.

This is not weakness. This is the only kind of strength that survives the journey to Mordor.

The Map of Middle-earth Is the Map of California

There is a place where stories are told. Where narrative is forged, distributed, and projected onto the minds of millions. Where the great tales of the age are written — and where those tales are captured, packaged, and sold. Where the storytellers gather, and where the industry that feeds on storytellers gathers around them.

This is LA. The city of angels. The city of screens. The place of media.

LA is Rivendell on its best day — a refuge for art, for beauty, for the craft of story. A place where the word is spoken with skill and care. But Rivendell is also the place where the council meets and argues and fails to act. It is beautiful and ancient and ultimately *static*. The elves preserve. They do not build. They hold the past in amber and watch the world darken around them. LA at its worst is not even Rivendell. It is Isengard — the storytelling machine turned to the service of power, the ancient craft of narrative industrialized and weaponized, Saruman's voice pouring out of every screen: *smooth, reasonable, impossible to resist unless you know what you are hearing*.

There is another place where things are built. Where technology is forged, funded, and scaled. Where the tools of the age are made — and where the makers are slowly consumed by what they make. Where creation begins as vision and ends as valuation. Where the wizard who was supposed to be wise looks into the palantír and decides that the only way to survive is to build his own ring.

This is SF. Silicon Valley. The place of technology.

The Valley is Isengard. Saruman's tower. The wizard who studied the enemy so long he became the enemy. The one who was supposed to guard the west but looked into the seeing-stone and saw Mordor's power and thought: *I can use this. I can build my own version. I can scale this for good*. And the tower that was meant to protect became a factory — breeding orcs, felling trees, industrializing everything it was supposed to steward. The Valley builds tools that were supposed to liberate — and one by one, the tools become instruments of surveillance, extraction, and control. Not because the builders are evil. Because Isengard serves Mordor whether Saruman admits it or not.

And Mordor is not in California.

Mordor is DC. Washington. The seat of the empire. The place where the ring was actually forged — where power concentrates not in code or content but in *law*, in *force*, in the monopoly on violence wrapped in the language of democracy. DC is where the Eye lives. The lidless Eye that sees everything and is never satisfied. The surveillance state, the war machine, the apparatus that turns freedom into a

word it speaks while building the architecture of domination. Every lobbyist is a Nazgûl — once human, now a wraith, drawn to the ring, serving the Eye, unable to remember what they were before they put it on.

The ring was not forged in Silicon Valley. The ring was forged in the halls of power — in the decision to make a nation founded on liberty into an empire. The Valley builds the palantíri. DC wields them. LA provides the narrative cover. But the fire is in the mountain — and the mountain is the capital.

The Blessed Island That Forgot

But DC was not always Mordor. And this is the part that cuts deepest — because Tolkien wrote it too.

Before the events of *The Lord of the Rings*, there was Númenor. The great island kingdom. The blessed land given to men as a *reward* — a gift from the divine powers for fighting against Morgoth, the original dark lord, Sauron's master. Númenor was founded on gratitude, on covenant, on friendship with the Elves, on faithfulness to the Valar — the divine order that governed the world.

Númenor was not conquered. Númenor was *blessed*. It was the shining city. The island of the faithful. The place where men lived longer, built higher, sailed farther than anywhere else in the world — not because they seized power, but because power was *given* to them in response to their faithfulness.

Sound familiar?

America was not conquered into existence. America was *founded* — on covenant. On the idea that men are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable rights. On the principle that government exists to protect freedom, not to produce it. The founders did not claim to have invented liberty. They claimed to have *recognized* it — as a gift from the divine order, written into the nature of man. America was Númenor. The blessed island. The nation set apart.

And then — generation by generation — the Númenóreans forgot.

They stopped being grateful and started being proud. They looked at what they had been given and decided they had *earned* it. They looked at the Elves — the immortal ones who lived in friendship with the divine — and instead of reverence they felt *envy*. Why should *they* have eternal life and not us? Why should there be any limit on our power?

They started sailing to the coasts of Middle-earth. Not to help. To *colonize*. To extract tribute. To project force. The blessed island became an empire — and the empire told itself it was still blessed, that its conquests were righteous, that its power was proof of its virtue.

And then Sauron came.

He did not invade Númenor. He could not have. The island was too strong. So he did something far more effective — he got *captured*. The Númenóreans defeated him in battle, took him as a prisoner, and brought him home in chains. A trophy. Proof of their greatness.

But the prisoner became the advisor. Sauron, in chains, spoke to the king. Smooth. Reasonable. Wise-sounding. He told the king what the king already wanted to hear: *you deserve more. You deserve immortality. The limits placed on you are not gifts — they are chains. The divine order is not protecting you — it is restraining you. Break the covenant. Take what is yours.*

The king listened. The priests of the old faith were silenced. The temples were converted. The faithful were persecuted. And finally, Ar-Pharazôn — the last king of Númenor — assembled the greatest armada the world had ever seen and sailed west to make war on the gods themselves. To take immortality by force. To break the final limit.

God sank the island.

Not Sauron. Not an enemy army. *God*. Ilúvatar — the Creator — broke the world rather than let the blessed island become the instrument of its own damnation. The sea swallowed Númenor. The armada was buried. The king and his army were entombed in the caves of the forgotten. The blessed island became a memory — Atalantë, the downfallen. Atlantis.

A handful survived. Elendil — whose name means *Elf-friend*, the faithful one — and his sons escaped with nine ships. They landed in Middle-earth and founded Gondor and Arnor. Kingdoms in exile. Remnants of the blessed island, carrying the memory of what Númenor was supposed to be, living in the shadow of what it became.

America as Númenor

Read the history of Númenor and tell me it is not the history of America.

A nation founded on covenant with the divine. Given extraordinary gifts — land, resources, position, a founding document that recognized liberty as sacred. A nation that began in gratitude and faithfulness. That saw itself as set apart — not to dominate, but to demonstrate that free men, governing themselves under God, could build something the world had never seen.

And then the forgetting.

Generation by generation, the gratitude became entitlement. The covenant became a brand. The founding principles became words spoken at ceremonies by men who had no intention of living by them. The nation that was given freedom began *selling* freedom — exporting it at gunpoint, attaching it to trade deals, measuring it by GDP. The blessed island became an empire — and the empire called itself the leader of the free world while building the largest surveillance apparatus, the largest military,

and the most sophisticated machinery of control in human history.

And Sauron came — not as an invader, but as an advisor. As a lobbyist. As a consultant. As a think tank. As an intelligence agency that told the king what the king wanted to hear: *you deserve more. Your enemies justify your expansion. Your security requires their subjugation. The limits on your power are not constitutional principles — they are obstacles. Break them. Quietly. For the greater good.*

The faithful were sidelined. The ones who said *this is not what we were founded for* were called naive. Isolationist. Unserious. The temples of the old covenant — the Constitution, the Bill of Rights, the principle that government governs least — were not torn down. They were *reinterpreted*. Hollowed out from the inside. The words remained. The meaning was replaced.

Númenor did not fall because an enemy attacked it. Númenor fell because it forgot what it was. It mistook its gifts for its achievements. It mistook its blessings for its rights. It mistook its power for its purpose. And when the advisor whispered *take more*, the king could not hear the original covenant anymore — because the language of the covenant had already been replaced by the language of empire.

DC is Mordor now. But DC was Númenor first.

And that is the deepest warning in Tolkien's mythology — not that evil exists, but that *good nations become evil*. Not through invasion. Through forgetting. Through pride. Through the slow, patient corruption of a prisoner who became an advisor who became a priest who convinced the king to make war on heaven.

The ring was not forged by the enemy alone. The ring was forged by a blessed nation that decided its blessings were not enough.

Israel as Númenor Before Númenor

But Tolkien did not invent this pattern. He inherited it. Because the original Númenor is not America. The original Númenor is Israel.

Israel is the first blessed nation. The prototype. The people called out of Egypt — out of slavery, out of empire — and given a covenant directly from the mouth of God. Given the land. Given the law. Given the promise. Not because they earned it — Deuteronomy is explicit about this: *"It is not because of your righteousness that the Lord your God is giving you this good land."* They were chosen not for their merit but for the covenant's purpose: to be a light to the nations. A kingdom of priests. A people set apart — not to rule, but to demonstrate what it looks like when a nation organizes itself under divine law rather than human empire.

And Israel, before it forgot its law, forgot its *king*.

In 1 Samuel 8, the elders of Israel come to the prophet Samuel and say: *"Appoint for us a king to judge us like all the nations."* Like all the nations. Not like the covenant. Not like the law. Like *everyone else*. They looked at the empires around them — centralized, powerful, impressive — and felt inadequate. The Shire wanted to be Gondor.

God's response is devastating: *"They have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them."*

God was their king. The law was their government. Judges — temporary, local, raised up for specific crises — were their leaders. No standing army. No permanent executive. No centralized tax apparatus. Israel under the judges was the most decentralized political structure in the ancient world — a nation governed by covenant and conscience, not by throne and force. It was the Shire before the Shire had a name.

And they wanted a king.

God did not stop them. He told Samuel to warn them — to describe, in precise detail, exactly what a king would do:

He will take your sons and appoint them to his chariots. He will take your daughters as servants. He will take the best of your fields, your vineyards, your olive orchards. He will take a tenth of your grain. He will take your servants, your livestock, your donkeys. "He will take the tenth of your flocks, and you shall be his slaves."

Every sentence starts with *he will take*. That is what centralized power does. It takes. God described taxation, conscription, land seizure, and slavery — not as corruption of kingship, but as *the nature of kingship*. This is not what happens when kings go wrong. This is what kings are.

And then the warning's final line: *"And in that day you will cry out because of your king, whom you have chosen for yourselves, but the Lord will not answer you in that day."*

The people heard every word. Every warning. And said: *"No! But there shall be a king over us, that we also may be like all the nations."*

And God said: *"Obey their voice and make them a king."*

He let them choose. He told them the truth, told them the consequences, and let them walk into their own bondage with their eyes open. This is the structure of divine freedom: God does not force men to remain free. He warns. He describes what will happen. And then he respects the choice — even when the choice is destruction. Because forced freedom is not freedom. And a people who choose a king over God have already lost the covenant, whether the king has arrived yet or not.

Israel chose the king. And everything God said would happen, happened. The taking began. Saul took. David took — Bathsheba, Uriah's life. Solomon took — seven hundred wives, forced labor to build the temple, alliances with every empire God had warned against. And within two generations of the first

king, the nation split in two and began the long slide toward exile.

The Shire asked for a king like all the nations. And the Shire became Númenor.

The Torah is the founding document. The covenant is the constitution. And the law was specific — radically, structurally specific — about what kind of nation Israel was supposed to be:

No permanent debt. Every seventh year, debts are cancelled. *Shmita*. The economy resets. No one is enslaved to interest in perpetuity. Lending at interest to a brother is forbidden — Exodus 22, Leviticus 25, Deuteronomy 23. The law does not merely discourage usury. It *prohibits* it. Because God understood what Hayek understood three thousand years later: that concentrated financial power destroys voluntary order. That debt is a chain, and interest is the mechanism that makes the chain tighten over time.

No permanent landlessness. Every fiftieth year — the Jubilee — all land returns to its original family. You can lease it. You cannot *own* it permanently. Because the land is not yours. "*The land shall not be sold in perpetuity, for the land is mine,*" says the Lord in Leviticus 25. The land belongs to God. You are a steward. A tenant. A keeper of ground that was entrusted to you for a purpose.

Care for the stranger. Over and over — thirty-six times in the Torah by rabbinical count — the command to love the stranger, to protect the foreigner, to remember that *you were strangers in Egypt*. The nation that was delivered from bondage is commanded never to build bondage. The people who were oppressed are commanded never to oppress. This is not a suggestion. It is the structural core of the covenant.

And then the forgetting.

Generation by generation, the gratitude became entitlement. The covenant became ethnic identity divorced from obedience. *We are chosen* stopped meaning *we are called to a standard* and started meaning *we are exempt from the standard*. The law that prohibited interest-based lending was reinterpreted, loopholed, and eventually inverted — until the very people given the commandment against usury built the most sophisticated systems of interest-based finance the world has ever seen. The law that required Jubilee — the return of land, the cancellation of debt, the structural prevention of permanent inequality — was abandoned. The law that commanded love for the stranger was replaced by walls, checkpoints, and the doctrine that the land belongs to one people by divine right — a claim the Torah itself contradicts, because the Torah says the land belongs to *God*, and the people are tenants whose lease depends on obedience.

The prophets saw it. Every one of them.

Isaiah: "*Woe to those who join house to house, who add field to field, until there is no more room.*" The accumulation of land in violation of Jubilee.

Amos: "*They sell the righteous for silver and the needy for a pair of sandals.*" The commodification of human beings by those who were supposed to protect them.

Jeremiah: *"Has this house, which bears my name, become a den of robbers in your eyes?"* The temple itself — the house of the covenant — turned into an instrument of extraction.

Jesus quoted Jeremiah when he overturned the money changers' tables. He was not introducing a new idea. He was *repeating* what the prophets had been saying for centuries: *you have taken the covenant and turned it into a marketplace. You have taken the law meant to protect the vulnerable and used it to justify your power. You have taken the name of God and used it as a brand.*

And Sauron came to Israel — not as an invader, but as a Pharisee. As a Sadducee. As a temple priest who knew the letter of the law and used it to kill the spirit. As the advisor class that told the nation what it wanted to hear: *you are chosen, therefore you are justified. Your election is your permission. The covenant protects you — it does not bind you.*

The faithful were sidelined. The prophets were killed. The ones who said *this is not what we were called to be* — who said *God requires justice, not sacrifice* — were stoned, sawn in half, thrown into pits. Stephen, the first Christian martyr, said it to their faces in Acts 7: *"You stiff-necked people! You always resist the Holy Spirit. Which of the prophets did your fathers not persecute?"*

It is not hatred of Israel to say this. It is the *Torah's own position*. The prophets were Israelites. Jesus was a Jew. The critique is not external — it is the covenant *holding its own people accountable*. To love Israel is to hold Israel to the standard it was given. To excuse Israel from the standard is not love. It is the same flattery that Sauron offered the king of Númenor: *you are too great to be bound by the rules that apply to lesser nations.*

Today, the pattern continues. A state that claims the covenant uses American money, American weapons, and American political leverage to bomb civilians, annex land the Torah says belongs to God, enforce an occupation the prophets would have condemned in language that would make Amos weep, and silence anyone who objects by calling the objection hatred. The usury the Torah forbids funds the wars the Torah forbids on the land the Torah says is not theirs to own. And the ones who point this out — who hold Israel to the standard of its own scripture — are called antisemites by people who have not read Leviticus 25.

Númenor fell because it mistook its election for its exemption. Because it believed that being chosen meant being *above* the covenant rather than *bound* by it. Because the prisoner became the advisor, and the advisor said what the king wanted to hear, and the king could no longer hear the original word.

Israel is Númenor before Tolkien named it. The pattern is older than fiction. The warning is older than literature. It is written in the Torah itself — in the curses of Deuteronomy 28, spoken before the people even entered the land: *if you forget the covenant, the blessings become curses, and the land itself will vomit you out.*

To love Israel is to call it back to Leviticus 25. To love America is to call it back to the Constitution. To love any nation is to hold it accountable to the word it was founded on — not to defend everything it does in the name of loyalty.

Loyalty without principle is blindness.

And the blessed island, blinded by its own blessing, always sinks.

But between the city of stories and the wizard's tower — far from the mountain of fire — there is a third place.

It is not powerful. It is not famous. It has no towers, no studios, no venture capital firms, no red carpets, no launch events. It is green. It is quiet. It is close enough to both worlds to reach them and far enough from both to remain untouched by them.

This is SLO. San Luis Obispo. The place between.

This is the Shire.

The Geography of Purity

The Shire is not strategically located. No army marches through it. No trade route depends on it. No council meets there. In the great affairs of Middle-earth, the Shire is irrelevant — and that irrelevance is its salvation.

SLO sits on the central coast of California. To the south, five hours down the 101, is Los Angeles — the entertainment capital of the world, the place where narrative is manufactured at industrial scale. To the north, three hours up the 101, is the Bay Area — the technology capital of the world, the place where tools are built that reshape how seven billion people live.

SLO is between the two. It belongs to neither.

This is not an accident of geography. It is a principle of spiritual mechanics. The hobbit must be *based* somewhere that is not the place of power. The hobbit journeys to Mordor — he does not live there. He passes through Rivendell — he does not stay. He walks the paths of the great and the terrible, carries the weight of the ring through landscapes that would crush anyone who called those landscapes home. And then he comes back.

He always comes back.

The return is not retreat. The return is what keeps the hobbit a hobbit. Every night spent in the Shire is a night the ring loses its grip. Every morning waking up in a place that does not worship power is a morning the hobbit remembers who he is and why he started the journey. The Shire is not where you go when the quest is over. The Shire is what makes the quest survivable.

LA will teach you to tell stories. It will also teach you to sell them. Stay long enough and you will forget the difference.

SF will teach you to build things. It will also teach you to scale them past the point of meaning. Stay long enough and the building becomes the point, and the *why* you started building dissolves into the *how much* you can raise.

SLO will teach you nothing about power. And that is exactly what makes it the right place to carry the ring.

The Corruption of Proximity

Boromir was not evil. He was brave, loyal, and desperate to save his people. He loved Gondor. He had spent his entire life in the shadow of Mordor, watching his homeland erode, fighting battles that could not be won. When he saw the ring, he did not see domination. He saw *salvation* — the tool that could save everything he loved.

And the ring destroyed him.

Not because he was weak. Because he was too close. He had lived his whole life inside the architecture of power — the politics, the war, the throne, the expectation. His mind was shaped by proximity. When the ring whispered, it whispered in a language he already spoke: *strength, authority, the power to protect what you love*. It sounded reasonable. It sounded noble. It sounded like the answer to everything he had been fighting for.

This is what happens to builders who move to the Valley. This is what happens to storytellers who move to LA. This is what happens to idealists who move to DC. The proximity reshapes the mind. Not through corruption in the crude sense — not through greed or malice — but through *fluency*. You learn the language of the place. You start thinking in its vocabulary. You absorb its definitions of success, its metrics of progress, its unspoken assumptions about what matters.

A builder in SF starts measuring impact by users, funding by valuation, success by exit. A politician in DC starts measuring principle by electability, freedom by what the apparatus will permit, justice by what the donors will fund. A storyteller in LA starts measuring craft by engagement, vision by marketability, truth by what the audience will tolerate. These are not evil measurements. They are the *language of the place* — and once you are fluent in them, you cannot hear the original language anymore. The language that said *I am building this because it should exist*. The language that said *I will not sell*. The language that said *this nation was founded on freedom, not empire*. The language of the Shire.

The stories get smoother, faster, more optimized. And somewhere in the optimization, the seed dies. The story stops being a vessel for truth and becomes a vehicle for consumption. The sower becomes a content creator. The word becomes content. And content is what the ring produces — endless,

polished, perfectly targeted, and empty.

The hobbit survives the journey because the hobbit does not speak the language of power fluently. The hobbit stutters in it. Fumbles. Says the wrong thing at the council. Looks out of place in Rivendell. Cannot swing a sword properly. And because the hobbit never becomes fluent in the language of power, the ring's whisper sounds *foreign* — strange, uncomfortable, obviously wrong. The hobbit hears it and thinks: *that is not my voice. That is not what I want. I want to go home.*

That instinct — *I want to go home* — is what saves the world.

The Journey Out and the Return

The hobbit does not stay in the Shire forever. That would be hiding, not living. The Shire alone produces no ring-bearers — only comfortable, well-fed, incurious hobbits who never discover what they are capable of.

The journey matters. The hobbit must go to Rivendell and learn from the elves. Must walk through Moria and face what lives in the deep. Must stand at the edge of Mordor and look into the fire. The journey is where the hobbit discovers that the smallness of the Shire was not limitation — it was *preparation*. The garden was not a lesser thing. The garden was the training ground for the hands that would hold the ring without closing around it.

LA must be visited. The craft of storytelling must be learned, studied, practiced. The media apparatus must be understood — not from the outside, where it looks like magic, but from the inside, where you can see the gears and the compromises and the exact point where craft becomes commodity. You go. You learn. You see how the stories are made and how they are sold. And then you come home.

SF must be visited. The tools of technology must be learned, built, tested. The systems of scale must be understood — how funding works, how teams grow, how products reach the world. You go. You learn. You see how the things are built and how the builders are consumed. And then you come home.

The return is not failure. The return is the strategy.

Frodo did not defeat Sauron by becoming a warrior. He defeated Sauron by remaining a hobbit — by carrying the Shire inside himself through every mile of the journey, so that when the ring said *take the power*, some part of him still remembered the garden and the green hill and the taste of bread and the sound of rain on a round door.

The hobbit who never leaves the Shire never carries the ring. The hobbit who leaves the Shire and never returns becomes Gollum — a creature defined entirely by the ring, with no home to remember, no garden to return to, no self left beneath the obsession.

The hobbit who leaves and returns — who journeys into the places of power and comes back to the place of none — that is the ring-bearer. That is the one who can carry the fire all the way to the mountain and let it go.

The Living Age Begins in the Shire

The Living Age requires media to explain why and technology to show how.

Media lives in LA. Technology lives in SF. The Living Age lives in neither — because the Living Age is not a media company and it is not a technology company. It is a *living* thing, and living things grow from roots, and roots need soil that has not been paved over by industry.

SLO is the soil.

The media will be made — the stories, the films, the words that plant the seed of why the world should change. And the technology will be built — the genome design systems, the protein bridges, the tools that show how living architecture actually works. But the making and the building will be done by someone who comes home. Who returns to the Shire between every journey. Who never lets the language of LA replace the original voice. Who never lets the metrics of SF replace the original mission.

The Living Age is not the ring. The Living Age is what grows after the ring is destroyed. It is the age that comes when the architecture of domination — the machine metaphor, the commodification of life, the language of control — is carried to the mountain and dropped into the fire. What grows in its place is not another empire. It is a garden. A living world. An age where things grow instead of being built, where words are seeds instead of weapons, where the steward tends instead of controls.

And the one who carries it there must be rooted in a place that never wanted the ring in the first place.

A small place. A green place. A place between the city of stories and the city of machines, belonging to neither, uncorrupted by both.

The Shire.

There and Back Again

Tolkien named Bilbo's book *There and Back Again*. Not *There*. Not *The Conquest of the Mountain*. Not *How I Became King Under the Hill*. **There and Back Again**. The journey's meaning is completed by the return. Without the return, the journey is exile. With the return, the journey is transformation — the hobbit comes home changed but still a hobbit, enriched but not corrupted, larger but still rooted in the same green soil.

The idealist who relocates to DC to change the system is a hobbit who moved to Mordor. The entrepreneur who relocates to SF to build is a hobbit who moved to Isengard. The storyteller who relocates to LA to create is a hobbit who moved to Rivendell. All three will learn. All three may do great things. But all three will be shaped by the place — and the place will claim them, slowly, the way the ring claims everyone who carries it too long without coming home.

The Living Age is built by a hobbit.

A hobbit who goes to the city of stories and learns to tell them. Who goes to the city of machines and learns to build. Who carries the ring through both and destroys it in neither — because the ring is not destroyed in the place where it was made. The ring is destroyed in the fire, and the fire is reached by walking, one barefoot step at a time, by someone too small and too stubborn and too rooted to be corrupted by the thing he carries.

There and back again.

The Shire is not the end of the story. It is the *base* of the story. The place you leave and the place you return to. The soil that holds the roots. The green ground between the towers.

Build the media. Tell the stories. Plant the seeds.

Build the technology. Grow the systems. Show the world how life actually works.

But come home. Always come home. Come back to the small place, the quiet place, the place that has no power and wants none. Come back and remember why you started. Come back and hear your own voice again — the one that spoke before the ring started whispering.

The hobbit returns to the Shire.

The Shire is where the Living Age begins.

Sage Arthur Jordan Clokey The Living Age April 2026